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SPOOKY STUFF

For Halloween, our guide to the scariest films of the 21st century **P2**



Craft is getting a glow up with designers transforming traditional weaving, metalwork, and natural materials into modern heirlooms

Objects of *desire*







(Clockwise from left) Studio Nyn x Kalm Village; Vähe Ensemble's Deco Passage; Boito's silk panels;Neytt's 1854 Collection;KULx Studio's coral centrepiece; Aku Zeliang's matkas; and Cherom Carpets x Studio Siriusdan. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT







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With a weaving legacy in Kerala dating back over a century, Neytt is finding new ways to bring textile craft into contemporary homes. The design house, which has also created a carpet for the Met Gala, moves beyond floor coverings with its 1854 Collection, a series of woven artwork made from raw sisal, New Zealand wool and bamboo silk.

Inspired by postage stamps, the collection translates Indian landmarks and cultural landscapes into tactile compositions. Delhi's Qutub Minar, Mumbai's Gateway of India and Kochi's backwaters become textile portraits, bringing architecture and memory to the walls.

"The secret to making history feel modern is reimagining its scale and use. For Neytt's 1854 Collection, we have transformed the humble postage stamp into woven wall art featuring Indian landmarks and cultural stories. By turning these historic references into bold, clean graphic designs, we ensure heritage feels neither dusty nor dated, but becomes a piece of structural art that brings rich human stories into contemporary homes," says Nimisha Srinivas, co-founder and creative director, Neytt.

Neytt is part of a wider shift in which India's textile and craft traditions are finding new expressions in contemporary interiors. Once largely associated with ceremonial use and furnishings, they are now appearing as wall hangings, tapestries, and sculptural objects.

At Boito, the Bengaluru-based design, art and fashion label founded by Richa Maheshwari, this exploration takes shape in What the Eye Remembers, a commissioned series of 12 handwoven silk panels presented at Nilaya Anthology's festive showcase, The Art of Offering, in Mumbai. Drawing on Odisha's Khandua ikat tradition and the rare Habaspuri weave, the collection takes lord Jagannath as its central inspiration, translating his distinctive iconography into a contemporary visual language.

"It's exciting to see textiles and craft move beyond clothing and find a place on our walls. When we treat them as art, they gain greater visibility and become something we live with, engage with and appreciate every day. It also gives traditional weaving techniques the space they deserve, allowing their stories and craftsmanship to be seen in a new light," says Richa.

Work of art

The conversation between craft and contemporary design extends beyond textiles. At KULx Studio in Mumbai, founder Kush Bhavani collaborates with Filipino artist and designer Bianca Carague on Pravāla, a collection inspired by coral. Rather than reproducing coral literally, the duo translates its branching structures into sculptural bronze forms and hand-carved wooden vessels.

For the festive table, sculptural vessels and centrepieces offer an alternative to conventional floral arrangements, bringing visual interest through organic forms rather than elaborate displays.

A different kind of intricacy informs Brass Fields, a collaboration between Namit Khanna, founder of Delhi-based Nama Home, and Indonesian designer Owen Pradipta Golim of Domestic Mass. Inspired by the layered contours of Indonesia's rice terraces, the collection translates the landscape into brass wall art, drawing on Moradabad's metalworking heritage and the Ulchai engraving tradition.

"There is so much intricacy involved in a craft like Ulchai, where artisans engrave fine patterns into metal using specialised hand tools. The hope is that when people encounter these pieces in their homes, they become curious about the craft, the people behind it and the traditions we risk losing," says Namit.

Architecture provides another starting point for Deco Passage, a collaboration between New Delhi-based designer Vaishnavi Walvekar of Vāhe Ensemble and Filipino industrial designer Clark Mendoza. Drawing on the Art Deco histories of Mumbai and the Philippines, the collection translates stepped silhouettes, geometric patterns and architectural rhythms into three sculptural objects.

Capiz shell creates a material connection between the two places. Derived from the windowpane oyster, it has long been used in Filipino homes and heritage buildings as a translucent alternative to glass. Goa offers an architectural parallel: before glass became widely accessible, translucent windowpane oyster shells were fitted into wooden window frames to allow air to circulate through small gaps.

"I think we're witnessing a return to our roots, particularly among our generation. With more nuclear families and fewer large, traditional family celebrations at home, there's a growing desire to recreate the rituals and traditions we grew up watching our parents and grandparents practise," says Vaishnavi.

The exchange between Indian and Southeast Asian craft traditions continues in Between Two Blooms, Shared Blooms and Tower of Blooms, a collaboration between architect and designer Nynika Jhaveri of Studio Nyn and Achariyar Sai Rojanapirom of Kalm Village in Chiang Mai. Working with brass, aluminium and copper, the collection draws on vessels used in Indian and Thai rituals, as well as the shared symbolism of flowers as offerings and expressions of hospitality.

A key reference is Dok Mai Wai, a traditional Northern Thai, or Lanna, metal-flower craft. Made from thin sheets of metal shaped into blooms and mounted to move, these flowers were traditionally worn as hair ornaments on special occasions. Their delicate forms carry cultural and spiritual significance, but the practice is now sustained by only a small number of artisans, according to Kalm Village.

In the collection, the detailing of Dok Mai Wai meets metal casting in Moradabad. Rather than reproducing the flowers as ornaments, the designers translate their forms and associations into contemporary objects, connecting two making traditions through the role flowers play in ritual, celebration and hospitality.

Come together

Motif and Meaning: The Human Hand in Indian Craft and Imagination, a specialised series and body of textile art introduced by the luxury Indian heritage brand Swati & Sunaina (known for reviving and innovating ultra-rare Benaras hand-weaving techniques) explores how textile motifs can inspire works across materials and techniques. Its Avataar motif appears in Benarasi brocade, French-knot embroidery, kalamkari painting and shola-pith sculpture.

Craft also becomes a meeting point between cultures in Parabula ng Matka (Parables of Matka), a collaboration between Nagaland-based Aku Zeliang, creative director of Heirloom Naga Centre, and Filipino artist and designer Allyza Tresvalles, founder of the weaving community Buntaleras. Aku works with indigenous crafts from Northeast India, while Tresvalles collaborates with local weavers to explore regional fibres and sustain traditional knowledge.

The collection began with two familiar vessels: the Indian matka and the Filipino tapayan, traditionally used to store water or food. Reimagined in cane and rattan, they become sculptural baskets that draw on shared visual references, including horns, spikes and jackfruit. Mouth-blown glass eyes and chrome-finished stainless steel add unexpected details.

For Aku, however, the conversation around experimental design must include the question of how such work can sustain the people who make it. In a conversation about Across the Lines, the exhibition he curated at Nilaya Anthology, he spoke about the need to balance creative ambition with commercial viability. "Established commercial work can help designers fund more experimental projects, while training programmes can give artisans new ways to share their knowledge and gain recognition," he says.

A new collaboration brings the conversation back to the loom. Entwine, by Cherom Carpets and Studio Siriusdan, began with an exchange between Abdullah Ansari, a third-generation carpet maker who leads Cherom in Uttar Pradesh's Bhadohi, and Cyrus Dan Cañares, a Filipino textile artist, writer and creative director based in Manila. Their shared interest in textiles led to experiments with wool beyond conventional carpet-making.

An early idea to combine carpet weaving with the Filipino banig, a traditional woven mat, evolved with the introduction of metal. The resulting works bring soft wool into dialogue with steel, exploring contrasts in material, texture and textile traditions.

These works also raise a larger question about the future of craft-led design: how can objects be both culturally meaningful and commercially sustainable? Collectible design offers one possible route, giving distinctive, often limited-production pieces a place between functional interiors and the art market.

In a world of fleeting trends and seasonal shopping, objects rooted in memory, tradition and the skill of artisans offer something more enduring.

Happy Halloween! We have been screaming our way through a horror marathon to bring you our picks from the 21st Century's most terrifying films. Lights off, volume up











Trick or *terror*

The complete list of the definitive scariest films of the 21st century

20. Noroi: The Curse (2005)
19. The Autopsy of Jane Doe (2016)
18. The Wailing (2016)
17. The Visit (2015)
16. Ringu (1998)
15. Undertone (2025)
14. Hell House LLC (2015)
13. Host (2020)
12. Last Shift (2014)
11. Insidious (2010)
10. Terrified (2017)
9. Evil Dead (2013)
8. The Taking of Deborah Logan (2014)
7. [REC] (2007)
6. Paranormal Activity (2007)

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Horror movies are spirit-cleansers that allow us to stare at our deepest fears and primal instincts. But what happens when that cleansing takes the form of an electronic exorcism? What happens when it is the dead of night and your soul is arrested within celluloid confines? Are you perhaps as twisted as the films you watch?

If you are as rabid about horror as we are, you have likely waded through the annual deluge of listicles purporting to settle the genre's greatest scares once and for all. So at the risk of adding to the noise and with some brazen awareness of our own pretensions, here is our shot at the same. We believe a good horror film should turn an atheist into a theist for that one night, or at the very least, bring you to your knees. These may not be the most iconic, technically accomplished or universally beloved films the genre has to offer, but after much deliberation, we are putting our money on these as the scariest films of the 21st Century.

5. THE DESCENT (2005)
Of all the films on this list, *The Descent* is the one we would least like to experience firsthand. If one has debilitating claustrophobia, being wedged into some subterranean crevice while God knows what skitters around in the dark is quite literally personal hell. If you've ever seen those memes about cave divers with perfectly stable lives voluntarily exploring caves named "Satan's Rectum" with a 0% survival rate, congratulations, you already know the premise. A horrifically gory, suffocating ordeal that keeps you drowning in dread until the very last second; curiously enough, this might also be the only film on this list to pass the Bechdel test.

4. THE CONJURING (2013)
Don't let the diminishing returns of its subsequent instalments rewrite the street reputation of James Wan's mausoleum to a new Hollywood horror sensibility. *The Conjuring* was a modern horror beast that understood that 'based on a real story' wasn't just a good marketing mantra; it was an insidious promise that ensured audiences carried the horror back home. Demonologists Ed and Lorraine Warren investigate the terrifying paranormal disturbances, but in truth, the one who will soon need an exorcism is you. If you survive, may you meet Valak next.

3. SINISTER (2012)
We cannot overstate how badly horror films that veer into snuff-film territory mess with us. There's a vicious, unvarnished realism to the cruelty that makes us forget that we are watching fiction and leaves us feeling almost complicit for having watched at all. Scott Derrickson shamelessly exploits that discomfort, luring us in with unsuspecting family footage before subjecting us to some of the most depraved, stomach-turning shockumentary sequences ever committed to film. Some of those images are likely going to squat in our brains rent-free forever. We also appreciate a good Slipknot reference.

(Clockwise from left) Stills from the films. CELADORFILMS, NETFLIX, MICHAEL TACKETT BLUMHOUSE PRODUCTIONS

2. INCANTATION (2022)
The most recent disruption to our sleep routine. The undisputed zenith of found-footage horror, this Taiwanese folk horror does the unthinkable: it makes us, the viewers, an unconsenting participant in its own grotesque mythology of desecration and damnation. The less we say, the better. The camera drags the viewer through the series of nightmarish forbidden rituals, ghastly deaths, and the gut-wrenching pain of seeing one's offspring suffer otherworldly traumas. One might be tempted to look up whether they are cursed for real. Regardless of where that journey takes you, nightmares for a few weeks are guaranteed.

1. HEREDITARY (2018)
The soul-sucking nihilism (complimentary) of Ari Aster's cinema may not be everyone's cup of tea, but his feature debut is an ungodly paean to suffering that everyone ought to subject themselves to at least once. Between Toni Collette's petrifying uncanny-valley performance and Aster's sadistically unobtrusive background scares, we have never found the cinema's walls, ceiling, floor or the palms of my own hands quite so fascinating. We don't think *Hereditary* is merely scary so much as fundamentally, almost spitefully evil, and anyone who disagrees deserves to be instituitionalised along with Aster. Oh, and Hail Paimon.







One fish, two fish

He is back, top hat and all. Warner Bros. brings Dr. Seuss's feline agent of chaos back. This time on a mission to help two siblings navigate a move to a new town. Expect mayhem, mischief and a lot of nonsense

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Dr. Seuss, the nom de plume behind which American author and illustrator Theodor Seuss Geisel unleashed his menagerie of linguistic oddities and peculiar flights of fancy, has furnished Hollywood with a colourful assortment of animated properties, including *Horton Hears a Who!*, *The Lorax* and *The Grinch*. Now, Warner Bros. Pictures Animation is having another go at *The Cat in the Hat*, bringing Seuss's top-hatted purveyor of chaos back to the screen for another round of feline fun.

Helming the film are Alessandro Carloni, whose credits include *Kung Fu Panda 3* (2016), and Erica Rivinoja, whose writing résumé spans *Cloudy with a Chance of Meatballs 2* (2013), *The Addams Family* (2019), and the Academy Award-nominated *Borat Subsequent Moviefilm* (2020). Their take on Seuss's iconic anarchist introduces the Institute for the Institution of Imagination and Inspiration, LLC (IIII), which dispatches the Cat to help siblings Gabby and Sebastian navigate the upheaval of moving to a new town. I spoke with Alessandro and Erica about turning a slim children's book into a feature-length adventure.

A recognisable troublemaker
First introduced in 1957, the towering, bow-tied feline's striped headgear and rubber-limbed physicality made him one of children's literature's most recognisable troublemakers. His characteristically cartoon gag physics places him among the company of 'Toon Force' characters like Bugs Bunny, The Mask, Popeye the Sailor Man, and *One Piece*'s Monkey D. Luffy. But Alessandro and Erica seemed more interested in what actually drives the Cat.

"The one that we always cite is Will Ferrell in *Elf*," Erica says, explaining that Buddy Hobb's apparent naivety concealed his sincerity. "There's something really fun about that," she adds, pointing to his unfiltered enthusiasm and excitement. She also cites Melissa McCarthy's physical comedy, while Alessandro acknowledges the resemblance to Bugs Bunny, with a caveat: "Bugs Bunny is definitely smarter and a little more cynical than the Cat."

Alessandro expands on why Ferrell's Buddy was such a useful reference. "There are very far and few characters out there where their sincerity and humbleness in public is exactly who they are in private," he explains. He also mentions Dory from *Finding Nemo*, before arriving at the essential quality they wanted their Cat to possess: "He's an agent of chaos, and he makes a big mess, but he does it with sheer sincerity of a love for what he does."

Seuss's alchemy of unorthodox rhyme schemes and invented words makes his books deceptively difficult to spin a script out of, with much of their magic residing in how they sound and look rather than how little actually happens.

(Clockwise from left) A still from *The Cat in the Hat* ; Bill Hader poses with the Cat at *The Cat in the Hat*; a still from the film; Alessandro Carloni and Erica Rivinoja. WARNER BROS.

Still, Erica found a fix: "I really didn't want to have to write an entire movie in rhyme. That seemed way too daunting," she admits. "The fact that the official IIII business language is in rhyme was a fun way to pay homage to Dr. Seuss without actually having to have an entire movie written in rhyme scheme," Alessandro reveals. Earlier drafts contained considerably more verse, including passages written in Seuss's preferred anapestic tetrameter. As production progressed, however, they repeatedly removed exposition since the animation could communicate the same information without spelling everything out.

Asked whether the original book was harder to adapt because of its brevity, Erica says, "If you read the book, it's pretty limited action and very small. He just shows up at the children's home on a rainy day, causes a mess and then leaves. But we used that to ask, 'where does he go after this day?' And that is what led us to the IIII".

Emotional support animal
Alessandro notes,"The kids almost look more confident by the end, while at the beginning they're a little timid and insecure. Could it be that The Cat is actually the greatest child psychologist ever? Someone who's able to give a kid exactly what they need and just disguise it and define their rule-breaking?" He explains how the question provided the story with an emotional purpose. "The journey is not just one of sheer fun, but you discover that the Cat knew exactly what he needed to do to help the children at the moment of need in their lives. He's an emotional support animal."

Any new adaptation must also contend with the infamous cultural afterlife of Bo Welch's 2003 live-action *The Cat in the Hat*, starring Mike Myers, Dakota Fanning and Spencer Breslin. "There was so much fun, weird, cool stuff in that movie, but ours is just so different, and we just wanted to do something entirely different and unique; something that was very much us", Erica says.

Alessandro believes,"...Dr. Seuss doesn't really create stories. He creates moments. He creates vibes. He creates emotions." He adds, "There's something so magical about reading a book as a child that makes you feel special about just one small feeling. And outside of his skills as a draftsperson and a poet, that is what is eternal about Dr. Seuss."



The Cat in the Hat releases in Indian theatres on November 6

Malayalam

Fails to utilise a promising concept



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Quite a few unusual writing choices can be seen in Prince Joy's *Titans*, especially with how it treats its protagonist Antony Yakuza (Jayasurya), a small-time outlaw. Although the hangover of Jayasurya's Shaji Pappan character from *Aadu* is very much visible in Antony, he is perhaps one of the most unheroic lead characters in a movie of this kind. In every situation, he is expected to either fail or do the wrong thing and he keeps up with that expectation much of the time.

The other interesting approach is in how writer James Sebastian portrays the done-to-death fight between good and evil, going behind the mechanics of how both sides operate, with Lucifer getting a glitzy corporate office and the other side in a location that is a stark contrast. Much of this might have looked great at a conceptual level, but it does not translate that well onto the screen.

Titans

Director: Prince Joy

Cast: Jayasurya, Vinayakan, Nihal Nizam, Baby Jean, Indrans, Sunny Wayne, Suresh Krishna

Plot: A small-time outlaw plans a major heist to make a name as a respected gangster, but things don't really pan out the way he wishes.

What one is left with are a few scenes where everything comes together well, interspersed with long intervals of uninspired writing. The banter between Antony and his roommate Anwar (Nihal Nizam) and the many hare-brained plans that they devise with getaway driver Rejimon (Vinayakan) throw up enough scope for humour, but they manage to pull it off only occasionally. Like the sequence in which they attempt a major heist using a gas cutter or the one in which they attempt to rob a bank.

If Titans appears better than the sum of its parts, a good part of the credit has to go to Vinayakan, who lends a lot of depth to the character of Rejimon, lifting the otherwise predictable third act. After a point, he single-handedly carries the movie. The action sequences in these parts are also effective, considering the limited budgets. Rapper Baby Jean is convincing as the local don, but he gets an under-written character with limited scope to perform. Nihal, as the tech-savvy fraudster specialising in digital arrests, manages to draw laughs with some one-liners.

One of the film's few positives is that some of the fantasy elements are seamlessly weaved into the story of a man aspiring to be a big-time gangster, that they almost seem believable. But the fact that women, except for a couple of blink-and-you-miss-it characters, are mostly absent from the film is glaring. None of them get even two or three lines to utter too.

Titans had a lot going for it at as a concept, but the makers fail to extract all the possibilities that it held.

Titans *is currently playing in theatres*



A promising but half-hearted horror

Produced by Prashanth Neel and directed by Kirtan Nadagouda, this horror film has a terrific beginning and striking technical craft, but eventually loses steam

Telugu

Srivathsan Nadadhur

How much do our horror films love the sight of a traumatised woman walking with a pair of anklets, creeping her targets out with a slow, haunting lullaby? Yet, clichés aside, *418*, the Telugu film backed by Prashanth Neel and helmed by his associate Kirtan Nadagouda, owes its initial freshness to the medical college setting in Vedagiri, Karnataka.

The campus backdrop lends itself to rebellion and adventure organically, where the characters are more often than not waiting to get into trouble. The typical haunted mansion is replaced by a boys' hostel, formerly a mental asylum shut down after a ghastly event. 'Strictly women not allowed,' reads a barricade at its entrance.

There is an inside joke in the hostel that the stern security guard would not even allow a female mosquito in, preventing any chance of a malaria outbreak. Birds and animals also avoid the premises. Set against the backdrop of 2020 and early COVID-19 fears, the story follows the introverted Vivek Shankar (Surya Raj Veerabathini) as he moves into a hostel room adjacent to the cursed, titular Room 418.

The nerves of the new joinees, the bonhomie, the animosity with the seniors, and their brush with freedom are contrasted well with the eeriness in their vicinity. They reside in a hamlet, cut off from the outside world, and are vulnerable and impulsive – ideal ingredients for a chilling mystery.

The film resorts to the most obvious of jump scares, using the jittery sound design to build curiosity around the haunted site, but some of the editing transitions are truly imaginative. A pivotal character is left hanging mid-air, the objects in his room fly out of nowhere, and few around him are willing to buy his eerie claims.

418

Director: Kirtan Nadagouda

Cast: Chaithra J Achar, Surya Raj Veerabathini, Preethi Pagadala, Charan Lakkaraju

Story: An introverted medical student moves into a boys' hostel adjacent to a cursed room, awakening a vengeful spirit.

However, what stands out at least in the first half is its raw, slow-burn anxiety. Viewers do not know what the storyteller is after. The grainy visual texture, mirroring the carefree early adulthood in a laid-back village with a smattering of pastel colours and the dim lighting in the night sequences, are a sight to behold.

There are hints of a drug-induced hallucination, visions of a *yakshagana*, a blossoming romance, where personal anxieties collide with the supernatural with a dash of innovation. While it cleverly reimagines the most integral tropes of the genre, it eventually falls prey to the stereotype.

A relatively primitive backstory around the female victim starts on a promising note – where the *yakshagana* tradition works as an allegory to condemn the pressures around motherhood. The tale pointing to the origins of Krishna, revolving around Devaki and Kamsa, puts this message across convincingly.

Yet, the director keeps cutting back to the present, employing several reaction shots to build anticipation (perhaps the *KGF* syndrome?). The growing insecurities of a newly married woman and the internalised misogyny of her female counterparts gradually translate into an unhinged rage, unleashing the demon within her.

The visual motifs, from creepy mirror shots to masks and stage fires, alongside underlying themes of caste and class discrimination are certainly worthy of exploration, especially in an era where women in mainstream cinema are so often reduced to mere carriers of offspring opposite hyper-masculine leads.

Unfortunately, this brutal critique of social ills resolves into a rather prolonged, ineffective finish. Vivek, who initially anchors our journey into the mystery, is unceremoniously cast aside. A clash among the students, compounded by the fury of the ghost amid a lockdown, is a fabulous idea for a climax, though the execution doesn't complement it.

The inherent tension of a female presence inside a boys' hostel is never fully capitalised upon, and the twists linking the ghost's past to the present feel unearned. What begins as an inventive reimagining ultimately succumbs to repetitive tricks and an abrupt landing.

418 boasts clear technical merits, particularly in a first half that taps into the viewer's psyche without abandoning genre staples. The impact is visceral when it dabbles with the unknown, backed by the solid setup, Dinesh Divakaran's cinematography, and the edits by Akul Avinash.

The minimalistic styling and compactness of the setting are a bonus. Composer Venky GG and sound designer Anupam C do a lot of heavy lifting even as the writing falls short. While placing Telugu-speaking characters in small-town Karnataka feels novel, the cross-cultural integration could have been more seamless.

Chaithra J Achar delivers the film's standout performance. Her external grace and vivid, expressive eyes mask her character's sinister ambitions. Surya Raj Veerabathini emerges as a promising find, steering the first half with his nervy, tense portrayal of Vivek.

Preethi Pagadala's feisty presence and Charan Lakkaraju's free-spirited performance also add to the film's freshness. Among others, Ramesh Indira and Goparaju Vijay impress in crucial roles, while Shrikanth Ganesh, as Mohan, deserved a more rounded character.

418 tries to give a new spin to a horror tale within the conventional boundaries of the genre, but it is half-hearted on both counts. There is a lot to appreciate on the technical front and the terrific first hour, though the real horror is the underwhelming payoff. In wanting to strike a balance between clichés and some of its fresh ideas, the film loses its way.

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418 *is currently running in theatres*

Manoj Bajpayee lights up a night to remember

Hindi

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A corrupt yet efficient cop is a lethal paradox but a rare breed in Hindi cinema. Most films give us clean heroes or cartoonish villains in uniform, even though our police stations have plenty of specimens like Ajay Nivrit (Manoj Bajpayee). Few Indian filmmakers understand the inner workings of our law enforcement agencies as well as Neeraj Pandey. In *Gajab Raat*, the writer-producer collaborates with director Ritesh Shah to look beyond cinematic stereotypes and show the power of an investigating officer if he decides to follow procedure.

A chameleon, Ajay, regardless of surname, is a quintessential Delhi cop who could have spent his formative years in Darbhanga, Kochi, or Pathankot. He does not compromise on law; he negotiates to mould it according to his interests.



Together with his immediate boss, SHO Rana (Rajiv Gupta), he manipulates the system to nurture his farmhouse dreams. One night, even before the dust settles after a raid in a cheap hotel, the dynamic moves from a lucrative extortion plan to a dark, high-stakes national security crisis.

Conscience comes calling when a young girl jumps off a moving SUV in Delhi's Connaught Circus. As the news spreads on social media, Ajay is assigned the case because he was close to the scene. Things take a turn when a series of high-profile characters start taking interest in the case. When a social activist (Shraddha Das), a CBI officer (Akshay Oberoi), and an NIA (Saqib Saleem) operative converge on the hospital, standard police protocol goes out the window. They swoop into the much-maligned sub-inspector's territory with a mission to strip him of his authority and oust him from the investigation.

But Ajay does not fold under administrative pressure, first for greed, then for justice. Deploying his knowledge of the systemic leverage, he stands his ground. Soon, Shah turns an institutional ambush into a chess match where everyone hunts everyone else to survive the night.

Loaded with stinging dialogue, it is not just about a rogue cop trying to make a quick buck. It gradually becomes a clinical dissection of how greed functions as a currency that changes form depending on which rung of the ladder you occupy.

While the rot starts at the top, the lower rungs smell it first and get tossed in the trash to protect the head. That the system functions as a transactional marketplace in which justice is treated as a commodity, and evidence and legal procedures are not tools to protect whistleblowers but are weapons used by pillars of democracy to maximise their leverage or protect their own skins.

For anyone who has seen the working of the system from close quarters, the conversation between SI Ajay and SHO Rana hits with a ring of truth. Playful but terrifyingly realistic, watching two seasoned operators feels like eavesdropping on an actual negotiation between two North Indian cops.

Bajpayee breathes a human soul into an otherwise commercial archetype. Here, he abandons slow-burning intensity for a rapid-fire, breathless dialogue delivery. Sharp and unyielding, his brisk, fast-paced cadence brings out the internal panic of a lower-rung policeman whose scheme spins out of control over a frenzied night.

Gajab Raat

Director: Ritesh Shah

Cast: Manoj Bajpayee, Divya Dutta, Rajiv Gupta, Akshay Oberoi, Saqib Saleem, Shraddha Das

Synopsis: *The thriller* follows a corrupt yet hyper-efficient Delhi Police cop whose lucrative overnight extortion scheme spirals into a deadly national security crisis.

A competent supporting cast helps create a credible atmosphere. Rajiv Gupta has built a career playing different shades of cops from the Delhi-NCR belt, and here he embodies a system too exhausted to be shocked, yet too smart to be outmaneuvered. Nushrratt Bharuccha is pitch-perfect in a high-impact cameo, and Shraddha nails the bindi-wielding stereotype of social workers. Akshay Oberoi is believable as the smooth-talking, deceptively mysterious CBI officer. So is good old Suneet Tandon as the corrupt colonial fossil of Lutyens' Delhi.

After *Last Man in Tower*, Bajpayee and Divya Dutta deliver another riveting face-off. Here, Dutta embodies a restrained, cold power centre. Her control is absolute, providing a strong counterweight to Bajpayee's manic survival instinct. An engaging plot and an electric ensemble make it a night to remember.

Gajab Raat *is currently streaming on Netflix.*

A body-horror thriller

English

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Clayface

Director: James Watkins

Starring: Tom Rhys Harries, Naomi Ackie, David Dencik, Max Minghella, Eddie Marsan

Storyline: An up-and-coming actor loses his face in a mob attack and goes for an experimental medical procedure to find himself drastically changed

Eye trauma and flight turbulence: Can Clayface be more revolting? *Clayface* is the third film in James Gunn and Peter Safran's four-year-old DC Studios, following *Superman: Legacy* and *Supergirl: Woman of Tomorrow*.

Directed by the excellent *Speak No Evil's* James Watkins, *Clayface* tells the origin story of the popular villain and sometime ally of Batman.With a story and screenplay by Mike Flanagan, *Clayface* eschews the 1950s iteration of the science fiction-inspired treasure hunter for the shapeshifter's origins in the 1940s *Detective Comics*.

Matt Hagen (Tom Rhys Harries) seems to have it all. Emerging from a tough childhood, Matt is now the toast of Hollywood. In fact, when we first meet Matt, he is getting ready for a shot, and a break is announced. Matt and his best friend, Corey (Joshua James), who is also an actor, hear the Best Actor nominations at the Academy Awards. There are congratulations all around when Matt's name is announced.

Matt and Corey head to Gotham for an interview with a popular talk show host. While partying at a nightclub, Matt is approached by a beautiful woman, Mia (Joana Ribeiro). Though warned by Corey to stay away from Mia, as she is the local mob boss, Markos Szabo's (David Dencik) woman, Matt has sex with her.

To his horror, he wakes up to Szabo and his gang of toughs at his bedside, and they slash his face with a switchblade. Matt's friends and associates, including his agent, Hildie (Nancy Carroll), and manager, Frank (Eddie Marsan), drop him.

Following a smear campaign and six expensive surgeries, Matt becomes an outcast, refusing to step out of his roach-infested apartment and unable to face the disgusted looks his badly disfigured face garners.

At his rock bottom, he sees a report on cutting-edge research by Dr. Caitlyn Corr (Naomi Ackie) where nano cells infiltrate the body to heal it. Matt visits Caitlyn and offers himself as a test subject, though she says they are at least a year away from human trials. Matt says he is willing to sign anything, and even if he dies due to the treatment, it is better than living the way he is now.

The treatment at first seems to go well, and Matt's face is healed, but of course there are side effects, and Matt soon finds his body taking on the consistency of clay. As his body changes, so do his mind and soul, letting his darker side take control.

After *Joker, Clayface* is another attempt to provide a Batman villain with an origin story to reveal a tragedy to be the driving force behind their nastiness.

Rhys Harries shines as the vulnerable, angry golden child, and his chemistry with Ackie is one of the strongest threads. Max Minghella brings earnest intelligence to his turn as police detective John Borrelli, investigating the rash of violent crimes.

The complete lack of lore is liberating. As long as one does not wander too deeply into the metaphor of clay being the building block of life, *Clayface* is interesting enough.

Clayface *is currently running in theatres*

Snippets



Ahaan Panday and Sharvari's upcoming actioner gets title

Ahaan Panday and Sharvari's upcoming romantic-actioner has been titled *Beparwah*. The production banner Yash Raj Films also announced that the film will be released in theatres on March 26, 2027. It also stars Aaishvary Thackeray and Bobby Deol in pivotal roles.

It is written and directed by Ali Abbas Zafar, known for making *Sultan*, *Tiger Zinda* and *Bharat* among others. *Beparwah* marks his return since his last directorial, *Bade Miyan Chote Miyan*, which came out in 2024 and was a box-office failure.

A poster of *Beparwah* was unveiled which features Ahaan and Sharvari in an intimate moment as he holds a gun while she has a guitar in her hand.



Dilwali Diwali: Netflix announces new family-drama for festive season

Streaming service Netflix has announced a new family-drama, *Dilwali Diwali*, which will be released on the platform on November 5. The film stars Mihir Ahuja, Manoj Pahwa, Neelu Kohli and Aurra Bhatnagar in pivotal roles.

Dilwali Diwali marks another collaboration between Terribly Tiny Tales (TTT) and Netflix. It is written by Ritu Mago, directed by Ritesh Menon. It tells the story of a Punjabi household where Ansh Sikkha (Mihir) returns home for Diwali after years of working abroad. "As the Sikkas come together for Diwali, their differing ideas of what makes a good life spark moments of humour, tenderness, and recognition," read the release.



Rukmini Vasanth teams up with director Shree Karthick

Actor Rukmini Vasanth will next be seen in a film directed by Shree Karthick. The filmmaker is known for his debut feature, the science fiction Telugu drama *Oke Oka Jeevitham* (*Kanam* in Tamil). The movie is produced by Madboys Entertainment and Siruni Cine Corporation.

Dev Ramnath and Vinayak Vaithianathan will also star in the yet-to-be-titled movie. The announcement was made through a fun video. The video shows the film team visiting Rukmini's office to narrate the script. She appears like she is impressed with the story and her character is then introduced as Thara.

Rukmini was last seen in the pan-Indian film *Toxic*.



One Shibal after another

Who knew an alien invasion movie with a diarrhoea monologue could be this exhilarating?

Korean

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Hope

Director: Na Hong-jin

Cast: Hwang Jung-min, Zo In-sung, Jung Ho-yeon, Lee Sang-hee, Eum Moon-suk, Taylor Russell, Cameron Britton, Alicia Vikander, Michael Fassbender

Storyline: A police chief, a policewoman and a group of hunters try to track down and kill a mysterious creature that's laying waste to a Korean village

I watched *The Wailing* during lockdown, and Na Hong-jin's 2016 nightmare has spent the years since burrowing into my brain. Naturally, I've spent the better part of a decade wondering what Na could possibly follow it with, especially after ten years to brood over his next move. While his latest Cannes-premiering *Hope* has not displaced its predecessor in my affections, it makes for a fascinating departure from the kind of exhilaration that first made me a fan of his work.

Written, directed and co-produced by Na, *Hope* assembles Hwang Jung-min, Zo In-sung, Jung Ho-yeon, Taylor Russell, Cameron Britton, Alicia Vikander and Michael Fassbender for an extraterrestrial invasion in a South Korean settlement. Having watched the film, I've decided it can be divided into three distinct acts: **Shibal, Diarrhoea Interlude** and **More Shibal**.

Hope Harbor is a sleepy South Korean village near the DMZ, where the elderly residents seem to have accumulated enough unregistered firearms to supply a small insurgency. Things begin with police chief Bum-seok and his cousin Sung-ki investigating a dead cow bearing enormous, inexplicable wounds. The hunters suspect a tiger that wandered down from the North, but when more livestock turn up dead and Bum-seok returns to find the town's streets and buildings thoroughly demolished, they realise they have a much bigger problem.

From here, Na begins injecting pure nitroglycerin into our veins, and *Hope* turns into an extended chase sequence. A gaping hole in the real-estate office, mangled bodies strewn across narrow alleyways, and the occasional disembodied, bloodcurdling roar from just around the corner, followed by somebody getting flattened by a flying car or some other piece of debris, gradually reveal the scale of whatever has descended upon Hope Harbor.

Na milks this opening stretch for all its worth, keeping the creature frustratingly out of sight while Bum-seok scrambles through the wreckage. What makes it so effective is how meticulously he keeps raising the stakes without letting Bum-seok, or us, get a proper handle on what is happening.

It takes nearly an hour for Na to finally show us what's been tearing Hope Harbor apart, and the reveal is enough to explain why he kept it offscreen for so long. Bum-seok's horrified slo-mo *shibal* – one of roughly a thousand variations of the word he's already screamed into the afternoon – feels like the only appropriate response to what emerges. This is a humanoid extraterrestrial, with sickly green flesh, rotting teeth and matted hair.

There's something uniquely panic-inducing about being chased by an unstoppable creature that could tear you limb from limb and move at roughly ten times your speed. A giant kaiju can be terrifying, but its sheer scale makes the threat feel almost abstract; a monster that is roughly human-sized, however, is close enough to catch you, and that proximity makes all the difference between some detached fear and genuinely wondering whether you'd piss yourself in the same situation.

For the next few minutes, my breath was held as the thing pinballed off debris with ragdoll physics, yet kept gaining on Bum-seok regardless. Bum-seok eventually gets some much-needed backup from Sung-ae, Hoyeon's trigger-happy rookie cop who seems considerably better equipped for an alien invasion than the entire Korean national security apparatus. It isn't long before the pair manage to turn the tables by blowing off the creature's leg with a grenade launcher before leading it into an absolutely bonkers car chase.

With the first creature apparently dealt with, *Hope* briefly catches its breath for the highlight: **Diarrhoea Interlude**. Having spent the previous hour dispatching an alien with enough firepower to make Ellen Ripley proud, the charming Sung-ae now has to sit through an elderly man's excruciatingly detailed account of his battle with diarrhoea.

As the final act begins, the aforementioned cousin Sung-ki and his hunting buddies have their own problems after stumbling upon a massive crashed spaceship in the forest, before being promptly ambushed by more aliens – this time including Alicia Vikander and Michael Fassbender. What follows is essentially *Predator* by way of a woodland rodeo, with the hunters scrambling for their lives over some of the most arresting horseback action I've seen in ages. The problem is that Na keeps returning to the same well long after he's squeezed most of the fun out of it, and watching these creatures absorb seemingly endless rounds of ammunition and grenades eventually starts to feel tiresome.

Naturally, the forest ordeal eventually spills into yet another car chase, this time with Bum-seok, Sung-ki, Sung-ae, retired colonel Nak-yeon (Lee Sang-hee) and Yang-bae, a spectacularly idiotic carpenter played by Eum Moon-suk who happens to be largely responsible for the entire alien fiasco, scrambling to escape Fassbender's particularly persistent extraterrestrial bodyguard.

The chase eventually reaches its conclusion with a *Hereditary*-esque payoff, before *Hope* abruptly veers into a confounding epilogue. I'll leave the specifics alone because this is one bewildering turn best experienced firsthand, although if I'm being honest, I genuinely have no idea what Na expects us to make of it. Has this been Na's *Digger*-style lampooning of the Hollywoodification of local film industries all along? It's difficult to tell where the satire (?) ends, and Na's own blockbuster ambitions begin. The much-discussed CGI is also undeniably clunky, to put it kindly, although it didn't pull me out of the film nearly as often as I expected. Perhaps years of sitting through Indian blockbusters with supposedly hundreds-of-crores worth "cutting-edge" CGI have conditioned me to expect very little.

That said, I'm genuinely gobsmacked by how willing *Hope* is to throw all semblance of restraint out the window just to keep the thrill-machine going. Honestly, I suspect Na knows exactly what he's doing. This is the filmmaker behind *The Wailing*, after all, and I find it hard to believe someone so meticulous about building tension doesn't understand the kind of lunacy he's unleashing here. When it gets going, there's a real thrill in watching it commit so completely to the bit, and it's what makes *Hope* such a singular cinematic experience.

Hope *is currently running in theatres*